



A STEP-BY-STEP WORKBOOK

The Beginner's Budget Guide

Take control of your money in 30 days

TUCKER TECHNOLOGIES

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Welcome

If money feels stressful, confusing, or like it disappears the moment it arrives, you are not alone, and you are in the right place.

This guide is written for real beginners. You don't need to be good at math, earn a big salary, or have your life perfectly together. You just need a pen, about an hour a week, and a willingness to look honestly at your numbers.

What a budget really is

A budget is not a punishment or a list of things you can't have. It is simply **a plan for your money, made before the month begins**. Instead of wondering where your paycheck went, you decide where it goes.

People who stick with a budget usually say the same thing: they feel *calmer*. Not because they suddenly earn more, but because they finally know what's coming and have a plan for it.

How to use this guide

- **Read one step at a time.** Each chapter ends with a small action. Do it before moving on.
- **Use the worksheets.** They're at the back of this guide. Print them as many times as you like.
- **Be patient with yourself.** Your first budget will be wrong. So will your second. By the third month, it starts to click.

TIP Schedule a 30-minute "money date" with yourself this week, right now, in your calendar. You'll use it to work through Step 1.

NOTE This guide is for general education only and is not personal financial, tax, or legal advice. For decisions about investments, taxes, or large debts, consider speaking with a qualified professional.

STEP 1

Know Your Numbers

You can't plan what you can't see. Before you build a budget, you need two numbers: **what comes in** and **what goes out**.

Your take-home income

Write down the money that actually lands in your bank account each month, after taxes and payroll deductions. This is your *take-home pay*, and it's the number you'll budget with.

- **Steady paycheck:** add up your paychecks for a normal month. If you're paid every two weeks, most months have two paychecks and two months a year have three. Budget on two, and treat the third as a bonus.
- **Irregular income** (freelance, tips, commission, gig work): look at the last 3–6 months and use your *lowest* month as your baseline. Anything above it is extra, not expected.
- **Other income:** child support, side hustles, benefits. Include anything you can reliably count on.

Where your money actually goes

Next, find out what you really spend, not what you think you spend. Open your bank and card statements for last month and sort every transaction into a category.

- Rent or mortgage, utilities, phone, internet
- Groceries versus eating out (keep these separate!)
- Gas, car payment, insurance, public transport
- Subscriptions and memberships
- Shopping, personal care, entertainment
- Debt payments, savings, giving

Most people are surprised by at least one category. Eating out, online shopping, and forgotten subscriptions are the usual suspects. That's not a failure. That's information.

TIP For the next 30 days, record every purchase on the Expense Tracker worksheet, even a \$2 coffee. Writing it down by hand makes you notice spending in a way that tapping a card never does.

Fixed versus flexible expenses

As you sort, mark each expense as **fixed** (the same every month, like rent or a car payment) or **flexible** (it changes, like groceries or entertainment). Flexible expenses are where you'll have the most control.

Your action for Step 1: fill in the *Income & Expenses Snapshot* worksheet using last month's statements.

STEP 2

Choose a Budgeting Method

There's no single "right" way to budget. The best method is the one you'll actually keep using. Here are four popular approaches. Read them all, then pick one to try for your first month.

The 50/30/20 rule

Split your take-home pay into three big buckets:

- **50% Needs:** housing, utilities, groceries, transportation, insurance, minimum debt payments.
- **30% Wants:** dining out, hobbies, shopping, streaming, travel.
- **20% Savings & debt:** emergency fund, extra debt payments, retirement, savings goals.

It's simple and flexible, which makes it a great starting point. If you live somewhere with high housing costs, your needs may be well above 50%, and that's okay. Treat the percentages as a guide, not a rule.

Zero-based budgeting

Give every single dollar a job until your income minus your plan equals zero. "Zero" doesn't mean an empty bank account; it means savings and debt payments are planned on purpose, not left to whatever's left over.

This method takes a little more effort, but it's the most powerful for getting control fast.

The envelope (cash-stuffing) method

Withdraw cash for your flexible categories, such as groceries, gas, and fun money, and put each amount in a labeled envelope. When an envelope is empty, spending in that category stops until next month. Many people use this only for their trouble categories.

Pay yourself first

As soon as you're paid, move a set amount to savings automatically. Then spend the rest however you like, as long as the bills are covered. It's the lowest-effort method and works well if you're naturally careful with spending.

Method	Effort	Best for
50/30/20	Low	Beginners who want a simple framework
Zero-based	Medium	Getting full control quickly
Envelopes	Medium	Overspending on groceries, eating out, or fun
Pay yourself first	Low	Steady savers who dislike tracking

Your action for Step 2: choose one method and complete the *50/30/20 Calculator* worksheet. Even if you pick another method, it shows you a healthy starting point.

STEP 3

Build Your First Budget

Now you'll combine your numbers from Step 1 with your method from Step 2. Here's a complete example to show how it fits together.

Meet Sam

Sam takes home **\$4,000 a month**. Using the 50/30/20 rule as a guide, Sam's targets are \$2,000 for needs, \$1,200 for wants, and \$800 for savings and debt. Here's Sam's zero-based budget:

Category	Item	Amount
Needs	Rent	\$1,250
Needs	Utilities & internet	\$170
Needs	Groceries	\$380
Needs	Gas & car insurance	\$240
Needs	Phone	\$60
Needs	Minimum debt payments	\$150
Wants	Dining out	\$200
Wants	Entertainment & subscriptions	\$90
Wants	Clothing & personal	\$150
Wants	Fun money	\$110
Savings & debt	Emergency fund	\$500
Savings & debt	Extra debt payment	\$300
Savings & debt	Sinking funds	\$250
Savings & debt	Retirement	\$150
Total		\$4,000

Sam's needs come to \$2,250 (56%), wants \$550 (14%), and savings and debt \$1,200 (30%). Needs are over the 50% target, mostly because of rent, so Sam keeps wants lower to make room for savings. That trade-off is exactly what a budget is for.

Your budget, step by step

- **Start with needs.** List every essential bill and a realistic grocery amount.
- **Add savings and debt next,** before wants. Even \$25 a month builds the habit.
- **Fill in wants** with whatever is left, and be honest. A budget with zero fun money usually fails by week two.
- **Check that it balances.** Income minus everything should equal zero. If it's negative, trim wants first, then look for savings on needs.

TIP Round your categories up to the nearest \$10 or \$25. Small cushions keep a budget from breaking over a few dollars.

Your action for Step 3: fill in the *Monthly Budget* worksheet for next month.

STEP 4

Spend Less Without Feeling Deprived

Cutting costs works best when you trim the things you don't care about so you can keep the things you love. Pick three ideas from this list to try this month, not all of them at once.

Quick wins (this week)

- Cancel subscriptions you haven't used in the last month.
- Call your phone, internet, and insurance providers and ask for a better rate.
- Switch to a store-brand version of five things you buy every week.
- Unsubscribe from store marketing emails and delete saved cards from shopping sites.
- Set up autopay for bills to avoid late fees.

Food and groceries

- Plan your meals for the week before you shop, and shop with a list.
- Cook double portions and freeze the extras for busy nights.
- Keep a "use it up" night each week to finish leftovers.
- Bring lunch to work three days a week instead of five, if five feels impossible.
- Eat before you go grocery shopping.

Everyday spending

- Use a 48-hour rule: wait two days before any non-essential purchase over \$50.
- Borrow before you buy: libraries lend books, movies, and often tools.
- Plan free fun: parks, hikes, game nights, community events.
- Buy quality secondhand for furniture, kids' clothes, and sports gear.
- Keep your fun money in cash or a separate account so it's clear when it's gone.

Bigger moves (worth checking once a year)

- Shop around for car and home insurance.
- Review your housing costs; it's usually the largest line in any budget.
- Ask your employer about benefits you may not be using.

TIP Small daily habits add up. Saving \$5 a day is about \$150 a month, or \$1,825 a year.

Your action for Step 4: pick three ideas and write them at the bottom of your Monthly Budget worksheet.

STEP 5

Build Your Emergency Fund

An emergency fund is money set aside for true surprises: a car repair, a medical bill, a lost job. It's what keeps an emergency from becoming new credit card debt.

Start small: your first \$1,000

Your first goal is a **starter emergency fund of \$1,000** (or one month of essential expenses if that's easier to reach). This covers most everyday emergencies and gives you breathing room.

Then grow it: 3 to 6 months

Once your high-interest debt is under control, grow your fund to **3 to 6 months of essential expenses**. For Sam, whose needs are \$2,250 a month, that's \$6,750 to \$13,500. Aim for the higher end if your income is irregular or you support others.

Where to keep it

Keep your emergency fund in a separate savings account, ideally a high-yield one, so it's easy to reach in a real emergency but not so easy that you dip into it for a sale.

TIP Make it automatic. Schedule a transfer for the day after payday, so saving happens before you have a chance to spend.

Your action for Step 5: open or name a separate savings account and set up an automatic transfer, even a small one. Use the *Savings Challenge* worksheet to watch it grow.

STEP 6

Pay Off Debt

Debt payments take a slice of every paycheck before you've spent a thing. Paying them off frees up that money for good. First, list every debt on the *Debt List* worksheet: who you owe, the balance, the interest rate, and the minimum payment.

Always pay the minimum on every debt. Then put every extra dollar toward **one** debt at a time, using one of these two methods.

The debt snowball

Pay off debts from **smallest balance to largest**, regardless of interest rate. Each debt you clear gives you a quick win and frees up its payment to roll into the next one. It's great for motivation.

The debt avalanche

Pay off debts from **highest interest rate to lowest**. You'll pay less interest overall, so it's the cheaper method on paper. It's great if you're motivated by math.

Debt	Balance	Rate	Snowball order	Avalanche order
Store card	\$600	18%	1st	2nd
Credit card	\$2,400	24%	2nd	1st
Car loan	\$8,000	7%	3rd	3rd

Both methods work. The best one is the one that keeps you going. If you're not sure, start with the snowball: early wins make it easier to stay committed.

TIP When a debt is paid off, don't absorb that payment back into everyday spending. Roll the full amount into the next debt right away.

Your action for Step 6: complete the *Debt List* worksheet and circle the debt you'll attack first.

STEP 7

Plan for Irregular Expenses

Many budgets break because of expenses that don't happen every month: car registration, holiday gifts, annual subscriptions, back-to-school costs. They aren't really surprises. They're just not monthly.

Sinking funds

A **sinking fund** is a small savings pot for a known future expense. Divide the total cost by the number of months until it's due, and save that amount each month.

Expense	Cost	Months away	Save each month
Car registration	\$180	6	\$30
Holiday gifts	\$600	10	\$60
Car maintenance	\$600	12	\$50

When the bill arrives, the money is already waiting, and your regular budget stays untouched.

Common sinking funds

- Car maintenance, registration, and insurance
- Holidays, birthdays, and gifts
- Medical and dental costs
- Home repairs and replacements
- Annual subscriptions and memberships
- Travel and vacations
- Pets
- Back-to-school and kids' activities

Your action for Step 7: list your irregular expenses on the *Sinking Funds* worksheet and add the monthly total to your budget.

STEP 8

Make It a Habit

A budget isn't something you set once. It's a quick routine you repeat. The good news: it gets faster every month.

Your weekly check-in (10 minutes)

- Record the week's spending on your Expense Tracker.
- Compare each category against your budget.
- Adjust if needed: move money between categories rather than overspending.

Your monthly money date (30 minutes)

- Review last month: what went well, and what surprised you?
- Update your debt balances and savings totals.
- Build next month's budget, including any birthdays, holidays, or bills due.
- Celebrate progress, however small.

When you slip up

You will overspend sometimes. Everyone does. When it happens, don't abandon the budget. Just move money from another category to cover it, notice what caused it, and adjust next month's plan.

A budget you adjust is a budget that works.

Your 30-Day Quick-Start Plan

Follow this checklist to go from zero to a working budget in one month. Tick off each item as you go.

Week 1: Get clear

- ☐ Schedule a weekly money date in your calendar
- ☐ Calculate your monthly take-home income
- ☐ Review last month's bank and card statements
- ☐ Complete the Income & Expenses Snapshot
- ☐ Start recording every purchase on the Expense Tracker

Week 2: Make a plan

- ☐ Choose your budgeting method
- ☐ Complete the 50/30/20 Calculator
- ☐ Build next month's budget on the Monthly Budget worksheet
- ☐ Cancel at least one subscription you don't use

Week 3: Protect yourself

- ☐ Open or label a separate emergency savings account
- ☐ Set up an automatic transfer to savings
- ☐ List every debt on the Debt List worksheet
- ☐ Choose snowball or avalanche and pick your first target

Week 4: Look ahead

- ☐ List your irregular expenses on the Sinking Funds worksheet
- ☐ Add sinking funds to your budget
- ☐ Hold your first monthly money date
- ☐ Celebrate: you've built a real budget!

TIP You don't need to be perfect. You need to be consistent. Keep showing up for your weekly check-in and the rest follows.

Worksheets

Print these pages as many times as you like, or use them in GoodNotes, Notability, or any PDF app that supports handwriting.

Income & Expenses Snapshot

MONTH _____

INCOME SOURCE	MONTHLY

SUMMARY

Total income

Total expenses

Difference (+/-)

EXPENSE	FIXED / FLEX	AMOUNT	NOTES

WHAT SURPRISED ME

50/30/20 Calculator

MONTH _____

MY MONTHLY TAKE-HOME PAY

\$ _____

NEEDS • 50%

Housing, utilities, groceries, transport, insurance, minimum debt payments

Take-home \$ _____ × 0.50 = target \$ _____

My actual amount \$ _____ My actual % _____

WANTS • 30%

Dining out, shopping, hobbies, entertainment, subscriptions, travel

Take-home \$ _____ × 0.30 = target \$ _____

My actual amount \$ _____ My actual % _____

SAVINGS & DEBT • 20%

Emergency fund, extra debt payments, retirement, savings goals

Take-home \$ _____ × 0.20 = target \$ _____

My actual amount \$ _____ My actual % _____

WHAT I'LL ADJUST FIRST

Monthly Budget

MONTH _____

INCOME SOURCE	AMOUNT

SUMMARY	
Total income	
Total expenses	
Savings	
Left over	

HOUSING & BILLS	BUDGET	ACTUAL

PERSONAL & FUN	BUDGET	ACTUAL

FOOD & HOUSEHOLD	BUDGET	ACTUAL

DEBT & SAVINGS	BUDGET	ACTUAL

TRANSPORT	BUDGET	ACTUAL

Expense Tracker

MONTH _____

[illegible]

Debt List

DATE _____

[illegible]

TOTALS

Total debt

Total minimums

Extra per month

MY METHOD

☐ Snowball (smallest balance first)

- ☐ Avalanche (highest rate first)

WHY I'M BECOMING DEBT-FREE

DEBT

WHY I'M PAYING THIS OFF



Sinking Funds

YEAR _____

Cost ÷ months until due = amount to save each month.

EXPENSE	TOTAL COST	DUE DATE	MONTHS	SAVE MONTHLY	SAVED SO FAR

TOTAL TO SAVE EACH MONTH

\$ _____

NOTES

Savings Challenge

GOAL _____

Saving for: _____ Total: \$5,050 Color in each amount as you save it.

\$1	\$2	\$3	\$4	\$5	\$6	\$7	\$8	\$9	\$10
\$11	\$12	\$13	\$14	\$15	\$16	\$17	\$18	\$19	\$20
\$21	\$22	\$23	\$24	\$25	\$26	\$27	\$28	\$29	\$30
\$31	\$32	\$33	\$34	\$35	\$36	\$37	\$38	\$39	\$40
\$41	\$42	\$43	\$44	\$45	\$46	\$47	\$48	\$49	\$50
\$51	\$52	\$53	\$54	\$55	\$56	\$57	\$58	\$59	\$60
\$61	\$62	\$63	\$64	\$65	\$66	\$67	\$68	\$69	\$70
\$71	\$72	\$73	\$74	\$75	\$76	\$77	\$78	\$79	\$80
\$81	\$82	\$83	\$84	\$85	\$86	\$87	\$88	\$89	\$90
\$91	\$92	\$93	\$94	\$95	\$96	\$97	\$98	\$99	\$100

DEPOSIT LOG

Money Date Checklist

DATE _____

WEEKLY CHECK-IN • 10 MIN

- ☐ Record this week's spending
- ☐ Compare spending to budget
- ☐ Move money between categories
- ☐ Check upcoming bills
- ☐ Transfer to savings

MONTHLY MONEY DATE • 30 MIN

- ☐ Review last month's budget
- ☐ Update debt balances
- ☐ Update savings totals
- ☐ Plan next month's budget
- ☐ Add birthdays, holidays & bills due
- ☐ Celebrate one win

WINS THIS MONTH

WHAT SURPRISED ME

NEXT MONTH'S FOCUS

Notes